

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Definition: monthly popularity ratings for 50+ languages based on search-engine hit volumes.

Data sources include Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ additional platforms.

Rankings indicate visibility and ecosystem activity, not direct code-quality or runtime performance.

March 2026 headline: Python remains #1 (21.25%), while C climbs to #2 with strong YoY gains.

Method note from TIOBE CEO: LLMs are not used as a primary metric source because they are trained on the indexed web.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank 2026	Rank 2025	Language	Rating	YoY Δ
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Gainers (Rank Improvement)

Perl: #24 → #11 (+13)
R: #16 → #9 (+7)
Swift: #26 → #20 (+6)
C: #4 → #2 (+2)
Visual Basic: #9 → #7 (+2)

Losers (Rank Decline)

Go: #7 → #16 (-9)
C++: #2 → #3 (-1)
Java: #3 → #4 (-1)
PHP: #13 → #18 (-5)
Kotlin: exits top 20 (#22 in 2026)

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Python: unranked pre-1991 → #26 (2001) → #8 (2006) → #1 (2026)

C: only language remaining in top 2 across all nine snapshots (1986–2026)

Java: rose to #1 by 2006 and 2011, then declined to #4 by 2026

Lisp: #2 in 1986, now #26 in 2026

Ada: #3 in 1986, now #14 in 2026

2002–2026 Trend Signals

Python peaks above 25%, then settles at 21.25%.

C shows renewed momentum in 2025–2026.

Java declines from 25%+ era to under 8%.

JavaScript remains comparatively flat near 3–5%.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2017	Not available in source data
2016	Go

Python total wins: 6 (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024)

C# wins in 2023 and 2025, signaling sustained .NET momentum

Go won in 2016, but now drops from #7 to #16 in 2026

Award definition: largest annual rating gain in TIOBE

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Portfolio strategy: keep Python central, but track its -2.59% YoY decline for long-horizon bets.

Systems roadmap: C's +2.02% and #2 ranking justify continued investment in C/C++ expertise.

Talent planning: prepare for bimodal demand -- modern stacks plus resilient legacy skills (Perl, R, Fortran).

Risk signal: Go's #7→#16 drop suggests reevaluating assumptions in backend/platform standardization.

Concentration risk: Python+C+C++Java account for 48.97% -- diversify tooling and hiring pipelines.

Execution recommendation: align hiring, training, and platform choices to trend direction, not single-point rank.